

Rock Outcrops

PHOTO BY ALAN CRESSLER

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Though often lacking merchantable timber, rock outcrops in Georgia were historically impacted by forestry operations as managers sought to use every possible acre for reforestation or access. These exposed features were used for skid trails, roads, and equipment staging, sometimes leading to long-term damage to fragile soils, rare plants, and surface hydrology.

In the past, prescribed fire was excluded to avoid damaging nearby timber, allowing woody encroachment and reducing the health of outcrop-adapted communities.

Today, rock outcrops are recognized for their unique plant species, habitat value, and ecological sensitivity. Forestry operations now aim to avoid disturbance, limit access routes, and reintroduce low-intensity fire to maintain these rare habitats.



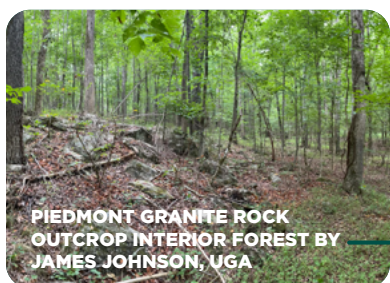
GEORGIA PLUME (*ELLIOTTIA RACEMOSA*)
BY BRAD WILSON

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

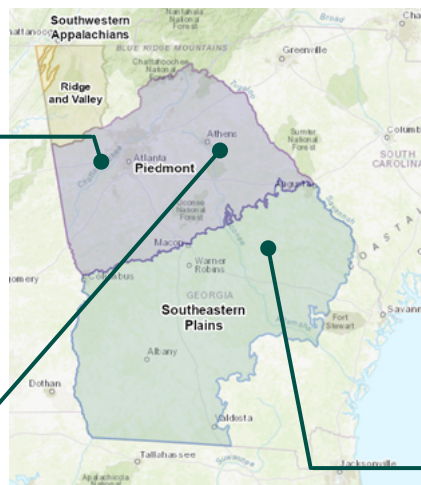
Rock outcrops – with exposed granite, sandstone, flint, and or kaolin –are characterized by several rare species and plant associations. Typically, these are open habitats with sparse vegetation surrounded by forest. They may have scattered shrubs or dwarfed trees (cedars, xeric oaks, and pines are most common); grasses in areas with deeper soils; and, may rise above the ground or be flat.



METABASALT OUTCROP BY
ALAN CRESSLER



PIEDMONT GRANITE ROCK
OUTCROP INTERIOR FOREST BY
JAMES JOHNSON, UGA



SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Limestone Glades and Barrens (Cedar Glades)

Sandstone Barrens and Outcrops

Granite Outcrops

Altamaha Grit Outcrops

Flint Kaolin Outcrops

Limestone and Marl Outcrops; Calcareous Bluffs

Southwestern Appalachians/
Ridge & Valley

Piedmont

Southeastern Plains



ROCK OUTCROP FOREST EDGE
BY ALAN CRESSLER

THREATS

- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Indiscriminate herbicide use or mechanical vegetation treatments can reduce plant biodiversity and negatively impact ecosystem function.
- Off-road vehicle traffic, mechanical clearing and other forms of trampling and soil disturbance

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Retire fire breaks and allow fires to burn through these areas when possible.
- Avoid placing roads, drag lines, and firebreaks through these habitats.
- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Clean vehicles, tractors, and equipment between sites if invasive species are present. If operations cannot be avoided in areas where invasive species are present, conduct operations in these areas last.
- Do not use these areas as logging decks, use old logging decks when possible or site decks in previously disturbed sites.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

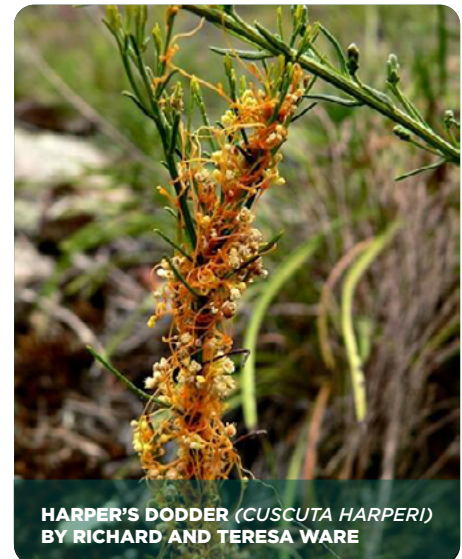
Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources



SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



HARPER'S DODDER (*CUSCUTA HARPERI*)
BY RICHARD AND TERESA WARE



CUTLEAF BEARDTONGUE (*PENSTEMON DISSECTUS*) BY HUGH AND CAROL NOURSE



LITTLE RIVER BLACK EYED SUSAN (*RUDBECKIA HELIOPSISIDIS*) BY ALAN CRESSLER



POOL SPRITE, SNORKELWORT (*AMPHIANTHUS PUSILLUS*) BY KEITH BRADLEY



GRIT PORTULACA (*PORTULACA BILOBA*)
BY ALAN CRESSLER

See full list of Species via QR code to left